

DIGITAL DIVIDE UNDERSTANDING THE GAP IN ACCESS TO TECHNOLOGY

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INTRODUCTION

The **digital divide** refers to the gap between people who have access to modern digital technologies—such as the internet, computers, and smartphones—and those who do not. This divide can exist between countries, regions, communities, or even individuals within the same society.





IMPORTANCE IN MODERN SOCIETY

EDUCATION

Students with internet access can attend online classes, research information, and develop digital skills, while those without access may fall behind.

HEALTHCARE SERVICES

Telemedicine and online health information improve healthcare access, especially in remote areas.

EMPLOYMENT OPPORTUNITIES

Many jobs require digital knowledge, and online platforms help people search and apply for jobs.

COMMUNICATION AND SOCIAL INCLUSION:

Digital tools help people stay connected through social media, messaging, and video calls.

ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT:

Businesses use digital technology for trade, marketing, and innovation. Communities with better digital access often experience faster economic growth

TYPES OF DIGITAL DIVIDE

ACCESS DIVIDE

This refers to the difference between people who have access to digital devices and internet services and those who do not.
Example: Rural areas with poor internet connectivity.

USAGE DIVIDE

This occurs when people have access to technology but use it differently based on education, income, or knowledge.
Example: Some users only use the internet for entertainment, while others use it for education or business

SKILL DIVIDE

Also called the **digital literacy divide**, it refers to differences in the ability to use digital technology effectively.
Example: Elderly people who may not know how to use smartphones or computers.

QUALITY DIVIDE

This refers to differences in the quality and speed of internet access and digital devices.
Example: High-speed broadband in cities versus slow internet in remote villages

CAUSES OF THE DIGITAL DIVIDE

ECONOMIC FACTORS

High costs of smartphones, computers, and internet services make technology unaffordable for low-income families. Poor communities may lack the financial resources needed for digital access.

EDUCATIONAL DIFFERENCES

This occurs when people have access to technology but use it differently based on education, income, or knowledge. Example: Some users only use the internet for entertainment, while others use it for education or business

LACK OF INFRASTRUCTURE

Also called the **digital literacy divide**, it refers to differences in the ability to use digital technology effectively. Example: Elderly people who may not know how to use smartphones or computers.

GEOGRAPHIC LOCATION

This refers to differences in the quality and speed of internet access and digital devices. Example: High-speed broadband in cities versus slow internet in remote villages

Differences Between Developed and Developing Nations		
Aspect	Developed Nations	Developing Nations
 Internet Access	High internet penetration and reliable connectivity	Limited internet access, especially in rural areas
 Digital Infrastructure	Advanced broadband and modern communication networks	Weak or underdeveloped infrastructure
 Affordability	Digital devices and internet are more affordable	High cost of devices and data services
 Digital Literacy	Higher digital skills and technology awareness	Lower digital literacy and limited training
 Use of Technology	Widely used in education, healthcare, business, and governance	Mostly limited to communication and basic services
 Education	Easy access to online learning and digital resources	Many students lack devices or internet access
 Economic Opportunities	Strong digital economy and more online job opportunities	Fewer digital job opportunities and slower growth
 Government Support	Strong policies and investment in technology	Limited funding and slower policy implementation
 Urban–Rural Gap	Smaller gap between urban and rural areas	Large gap between urban and rural connectivity
 Examples	United States, Japan, Germany, South Korea, Canada	India, Bangladesh, Nigeria, Nepal, Ethiopia

URBAN VS RURAL CONNECTIVITY



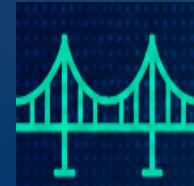
URBAN ADVANTAGES

Urban areas enjoy high-speed internet, strong infrastructure, wide coverage and better access to digital services and opportunities.



RURAL CHALLENGES

Rural areas face limited or no internet, weak infrastructure, poor coverage, and fewer access to digital services and opportunities.



THE GAP

The connectivity gap between urban and rural areas leads to inequality in education, healthcare, business, and economic growth.



BRIDGING THE GAP

Investing in infrastructure, affordable internet, digital literacy and inclusive policies can bridge the gap and create equal opportunities for all.

INTERNATIONAL STATISTICS

ON THE DIGITAL DIVIDE 2024



5.5
BILLION

Global internet users
people online worldwide



68%

World population using the internet
of the global population



2.6
BILLION

People still offline
people



83%

Urban internet usage
of urban population uses the internet



48%

Rural internet usage
of rural population uses the internet



1.8
BILLION

Offline rural population
offline people live in rural areas



93%

Internet use in high-income countries
of population online



27%

Internet use in low-income countries
of population online



51%

Global 5G coverage
of world population covered



84%

5G coverage in high-income countries
coverage



4%

5G coverage in low-income countries
coverage



79%

Youth internet usage
(15–24 years)
use the internet globally



68%

Gender gap in internet use
Men



63%

Women



Source: International Telecommunication Union (ITU) Facts & Figures 2024
<https://www.itu.int/en/mediacentre/Pages/PR-2024-11-27-facts-and-figures.aspx>



DIGITAL DIVIDE IN EDUCATION

ONLINE LEARNING CHALLENGES



EDUCATIONAL CHALLENGES CAUSED BY THE DIGITAL DIVIDE

ONLINE LEARNING CHALLENGES

- Poor internet connectivity affects access to virtual classes and educational platforms.
- Students in remote areas face interruptions during online learning.

LACK OF DEVICES FOR STUDENTS

- Many students cannot afford laptops, tablets, or smartphones for online education.
- In low-income families, multiple children may share a single device.

IMPACT DURING THE COVID-19 PANDEMIC

- School closures forced millions of students to depend on online education.
- Students without internet access or digital devices were unable to attend classes regularly.



ECONOMIC IMPACT



ECONOMIC IMPACT OF THE DIGITAL DIVIDE



EMPLOYMENT OPPORTUNITIES



- People with digital access and skills can find more job opportunities.
- Online job portals, remote work, and digital platforms create new career possibilities.
- People without access or skills are left behind in the modern job market.



DIGITAL BUSINESSES AND E-COMMERCE



- Digital tools help businesses reach more customers and grow faster.
- E-commerce and online payments increase sales and efficiency.
- Businesses without digital access face limited growth and competition.



INCOME INEQUALITY



- Digital access and skills lead to higher incomes and better opportunities.
- Those without access earn less and have fewer opportunities.
- The digital divide widens the gap between rich and poor.



Bridging the digital divide creates **equal opportunities**, boosts **economic growth**, and builds a more **inclusive society**.

SOCIAL IMPACT



SOCIAL IMPACT OF THE DIGITAL DIVIDE

How Limited Connectivity Affects Lives and Communities



COMMUNICATION BARRIERS



CONNECTED



NOT CONNECTED

- Poor internet access makes it difficult to stay in touch with family, friends, and communities.
- People in remote areas face challenges in accessing information and emergency communications.
- Language and digital literacy gaps further limit effective communication.



REDUCED ACCESS TO HEALTHCARE AND SERVICES



BETTER ACCESS



LIMITED ACCESS

- Limited internet access restricts telemedicine, online consultations, and health information.
- Difficulty in accessing government services, online banking, education, and other essential resources.
- Emergency alerts and important updates may not reach disconnected communities.



SOCIAL EXCLUSION



INCLUDED



EXCLUDED

- Lack of digital access can lead to social isolation and feelings of being left out.
- Students may fall behind in education compared to their connected peers.
- Communities without connectivity are less visible and less included in the digital world.



Bridging the digital divide is not just about technology, it's about creating an **inclusive** and **equal** society for all.



Bridging the Digital Divide

Government &
Organizational Efforts



Broadband Expansion Programs

Public Wi-Fi Initiatives



NGO Involvement



Role of Technology Companies in **Bridging** the Digital Divide



Internet Accessibility Projects

Affordable Devices



Digital Literacy Campaigns



Solutions to **Bridge** the Digital Divide

Improve Infrastructure

Expand broadband networks and connectivity



*Connecting Communities
for a Better Future*

Reduce Internet Costs

Make internet access more affordable



Promote Digital Education

Provide digital skills and training for all ages



Public-Private Partnerships

Collaborate with businesses and government



FUTURE OUTLOOK

How we'll scale in the future



Emerging Technologies

Innovations like AI, IoT, and blockchain will reshape connectivity and create smarter, more inclusive digital ecosystems.



5G and Satellite Internet

High-speed 5G networks and global satellite coverage will bring reliable internet access to remote and underserved regions



Need for Inclusive Digital Growth

Ensuring equal opportunities in digital participation is vital—bridging gaps in access, affordability, and skills for sustainable development.

SUMMARY

The digital divide is the gap between people who have access to digital technologies such as the internet, computers, and smartphones and those who do not. It is caused by differences in income, education, infrastructure, and digital skills. The digital divide affects education, employment, healthcare, communication, and economic opportunities, especially in rural and low-income communities. During the COVID-19 pandemic, the importance of digital access became more visible. Governments and organizations are working to reduce this gap through better internet connectivity, affordable technology, and digital literacy programs to create a more inclusive and equal digital society.





THANK YOU